

Realme 12 Pro

The design champion under ₹25,000

Among the plethora of budget offerings flooding the Indian market, the Realme 12 Pro stands out, thanks to its camera array. While many smartphones in this price range tend to feature token secondary or tertiary cameras, typically limited to 2-megapixel depth or macro lenses, Realme has opted for a different approach. The Realme 12 Pro and 12 Pro+ are among the select few to offer telephoto lenses, a rarity in the sub-₹30,000 segment.

In this review, we'll explore whether this move pays off for Realme and whether the Realme 12 Pro proves to be a worthy investment for consumers seeking an affordable yet feature-packed smartphone. Let's get right into it.

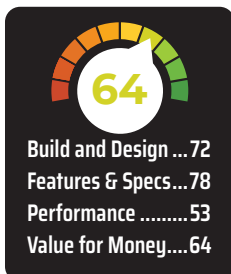
BUILD AND DESIGN

The Realme 11 Pro revolutionised the budget smartphone design game in 2023, so naturally, the Realme 12 Pro builds on its predecessors' success with a similar design language. The Realme 12 Pro features a softer vegan leather back, this time around, with an overhauled camera module design. The phone is available in two colourways – Navigator Beige and Submarine Blue, and we got the latter for review.

The Submarine Blue colour is a treat for the eyes. Clubbed with the premium gold accents that run down the back panel and around the camera module, the phone looks as good as an art piece. The Realme 12 Pro and 12 Pro+ are the best-designed budget phones in 2024 so far, in my opinion. They've both got similar looks, so you won't miss out on one of the primary appeals of this series even if you go for the cheaper 12 Pro, which is fantastic.

The rear camera module especially looks wonderful. Realme has roped in

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French luxury watchmaker Olivier Savéo to help design this phone, and the results of this collaboration are impressive. The camera module is meant to imitate luxury watch dials, and Realme has pulled off the effect rather well.

Regarding the phone's handling, it boasts a lightweight design, tipping the scales at a mere 196 g, delivering a delightful feel in hand. The vegan leather material on the back ensures a pristine appearance devoid of any fingerprint marks or smudges, while the phone's ergonomic curves enhance the comfort of the grip. On the front, you'll appreciate the uniformly thin bezels and a curved display.

The phone is rated IP65 which means it should be completely protected against dust and splashes of water (do not submerge it). The optical in-display fingerprint sensor is one of the fastest I've tested in the mid-range segment. In fact, it even beats out the speed of the OnePlus 12R's fingerprint sensor which is a much more expensive phone.

DISPLAY

Realme has opted to grace the new Realme 12 Pro with the identical display found on its predecessor, which is not necessarily a bad thing. Let me elaborate. The Realme 12 Pro packs a 6.7-inch AMOLED display with 120 Hz refresh rate and Full HD+ resolution. The display supports 1 billion+ colours, HDR10+, and up to 950 nits of rated peak brightness. Sound familiar? There is just one difference between the Realme 12 Pro and 11 Pro's displays – the touch sampling rate has decreased to 240 Hz from 360 Hz. However, the effects of this downgrade weren't too noticeable in my usage.

The Full HD+ display looks nice and crisp, the colours are vivid but not too artificial-looking, and the viewing angles are great for the price. HDR content looks great on YouTube, but just like with the Realme 11 Pro, HDR is not yet available on Netflix, which is very disappointing. If I'm paying for an HDR panel, I expect full support. Another gripe I have is the display's brightness. In my testing, the panel reached 898 nits of peak brightness under direct sunlight in Auto Mode, and while this is not a bad number by any means, there's no real upgrade here while other manufacturers are bumping up the peak brightness of their phones considerably. Overall though, this is a solid AMOLED panel that is complimented by a loud dual stereo speaker setup, that proves to be more than adequate for an immersive content consumption experience.

CAMERAS

The Realme 12 Pro is designed with two pillars considered – design and camera. The design, as discussed, is fantastic – almost unbeatable at this price. The cameras, in my experience, are one of the best under ₹25,000 as well. The company has included a new camera array which consists of a 50-megapixel OIS-enabled Sony IMX882 primary camera, a new 32-megapixel Sony IMX709 telephoto camera with 2x optical zoom, and an 8-megapixel ultrawide shooter. This is a huge upgrade over last year's dual-camera setup. The cameras do have some hiccups though, let's discuss them. The